

Hassan Sayed

hsayed@princeton.edu ◦ <https://www.hassan-sayed.com> ◦ 440-840-0898

Placement Director	Gianluca Violante	violante@princeton.edu	609-258-4003
Graduate Administrator	Laura Hedden	lhedden@princeton.edu	609-258-4006

Office Contact Information

Julis Romo Rabinowitz Building
Department of Economics
Princeton University
Princeton, NJ 08544

Graduate Studies

Princeton University	2019-present
PhD Candidate in Economics	
M.A. in Economics: May 2021	
Expected Completion: May 2025	

Fields

Political Economy, Economic Theory (Primary); Economic History (Secondary)

References

Professor Leah Boustan Department of Economics Princeton University 609-258-7116 lboustan@princeton.edu	Professor Ilyana Kuziemko Department of Economics Princeton University 609-258-8276 kuziemko@princeton.edu	Professor Pietro Ortoleva Department of Economics Princeton University 609-986-6895 pietro.ortoleva@princeton.edu
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Prior Education

Northwestern University	2015-19
B.A. in Economics, Mathematics, Mathematical Methods in the Social Sciences	

Job Market Paper

[“Persuasion with Partisanship: The Informational Content of Policymaking with Application to US Governors.”](#) 2024.

I study a model where a political executive's policy agenda generates information about her ability. Since policies favoring a single party are harder to pass, the partisanship of an agenda influences what success or failure of passage communicates about ability. The model delivers a U-shape relationship between an executive's ex-ante winning chances and her agenda's partisanship. Executives likely to lose pursue partisan policies to save their winning chances. Those likely to win embrace partisan policies whose failure can be blamed on the legislature. Those in the middle pursue bipartisan policies to secure reelection. I use these insights to analyze the partisanship of U.S. governors' policy proposals from 1990-2020, showing that while partisanship has risen on average, there is sizeable variation at the governor level. I interpret these variations as responses to electoral incentives by testing the model and showing a U-shaped relationship between partisanship and approval ratings.

Working Papers

1. [“Learning Traps.”](#) 2024.

Under policy uncertainty, policy choices generate a tradeoff between payoffs and information. Incumbent leaders can implement their preferred policy, but if the outcome is bad, constituents learn this and threaten office removal. I show that, in a repeated setting, the optimal policy of leaders constrained by this threat of information revelation is nonmonotone in beliefs about policy efficacy. At extremal beliefs, leaders experiment with the most extreme policy that keeps them in office. At middle beliefs, they implement spatially intermediate “learning trap” policies that halt learning about the optimal policy when it would be most useful. I apply the model to the post-1861 reforms ending serfdom in Imperial Russia, arguing that by combining elements of liberalism and serfdom to obfuscate inference about policy efficacy, these reforms represent a learning trap, in contrast to the pre-1861 status quo of serfdom and post-1906 experiments with liberal economic reform.

2. [“A New Interpretation of Productivity Growth Dynamics in the Pre-Pandemic and Pandemic-Era U.S. Economy, 1950-2023.”](#) With Robert J. Gordon. 2024. NBER WP 30267, CEPR DP19569.

This paper provides a unified framework that resolves why productivity growth in 2010-19 was some of the slowest in American history, why its cyclicality changed from procyclical in 1950-85 to acyclical in 1986-2006 to procyclical in 2010-19, and why it was strongly countercyclical in the recessions of 2008-09 and 2020. The fundamental dynamic driving cyclical productivity fluctuations originates in the gradual adjustment of hours of work to demand-driven output fluctuations due to labor frictions. We are able to explain the temporary 1986-2006 disappearance of procyclicality as the result of changes in the standard deviation and serial correlation of output changes. We explain countercyclical productivity surges in 2008-09 and 2020 by showing that business firms in those two episodes overreacted with “excess layoffs,” cutting hours in response to the sharp output decline with a much higher elasticity than normal. By coupling these excess layoffs with a post-recession rehiring effect that gradually unwound the excess layoffs, our regression analysis explains why productivity growth on average was so slow in 2010-19. In the absence of excess layoffs, productivity growth in the 2010-19 decade would

have been 1.9 percent per year instead of 1.1 percent, suggesting that concern about U.S. “secular stagnation” has been overstated.

3. “Transgressions in Organizations.” With Kim Sarnoff. 2025. (Draft available on request).

We study a model where an organization dynamically learns about the effect of managerial behavior on employee well-being. A manager takes an action of unknown harm, which an employee can report for investigation and possible punishment. These reports generate information for both managers and the organization. We show that the welfare effects of changing punishment, the efficacy of investigation technology, the ease of reporting, or the value of a manager-employee match depend on the severity of harm. When the harm is low, increasing these parameters may actually decrease employee welfare, either by motivating more managers to commit harmful actions that employees do not want to report, or inducing managers to opt out of matching with an employee altogether. The optimal punishment for managers can be expressed as a function of the harm, and may be interior. Employee welfare may decrease upon convergence to the steady state equilibrium, and in steady state, harmful actions are seldom punished and no organizational learning occurs.

Publications

1. “Transatlantic Technologies: The Role of ICT in the Evolution of U.S. and European Productivity Growth.” With Robert J. Gordon. *International Productivity Monitor* No. 38, Spring 2020.
2. “The Industry Anatomy of the Transatlantic Productivity Growth Slowdown: Europe Chasing the American Frontier.” With Robert J. Gordon. *International Productivity Monitor* No. 37, Fall 2019.

Work in Progress

1. “Inverted Digital Property Rights.” 2024.
2. “Model Based Inference.” With Kim Sarnoff. 2023

Research Experience

2022	Research Assistant to Prof. Roland Bénabou
2017-19	Research Assistant to Prof. Robert J. Gordon (Northwestern)

Teaching

Princeton	SPI 511b: Microeconomic Analysis for Policymakers (TA, Fall 2024)
Northwestern	MATH 220: Single-Variable Calculus (TA: Fall 2016)
	MATH 224: Single-Variable Integral Calculus (TA: Winter 2017, Fall 2017)
	MATH 230: Multivariable Calculus (TA: Spring 2018, Spring 2019)

Professional Activities

Presentations

- 2024** Princeton Industrial Relations Seminar, Princeton Microeconomic Theory, Princeton Political Economy
- 2023** North American Summer Meetings of the Econometrics Society, Princeton Microeconomic Theory, Princeton Political Economy
- 2022** Association for Comparative Economic Studies, Princeton Microeconomic Theory, Princeton Political Economy, Young Economist Symposium
- 2021** Princeton Microeconomic Theory

Refereeing

American Economic Review

Honors, Scholarships, Fellowships, and Grants

National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship	2019–24
Research Program in Political Economy Grant, Princeton	2024
William S. Dietrich II Economic Theory Center Research Grant	2022-24
Princeton University Graduate Fellowship	2019-21
Frederick S. Deibler Award for Distinguished Honors Thesis, Northwestern	2019
Interdisciplinary Honors, Northwestern	2019
Phi Beta Kappa, Northwestern	2019

News Articles

1. [“Transatlantic Technologies: The Role of ICT in the Evolution of U.S. and European Productivity Growth.”](#) With Robert J. Gordon. *International Productivity Monitor* No. 38, Spring 2020.
2. [“The Industry Anatomy of the Transatlantic Productivity Growth Slowdown: Europe Chasing the American Frontier.”](#) With Robert J. Gordon. *International Productivity Monitor* No. 37, Fall 2019.

Skills and Activities

Languages	English, Urdu; MATLAB, Python, STATA
Citizenship	United States
Activities	Princeton Lawrence Apartments Committee (Secretary 2021-22, President 2022-24); Adobe Creative Suite; Professional Photography

Last updated: January 2025